



INTERNAL · TEAM & SALES PLAYBOOK

The Smarter by 1 Degree Ecosystem

Who we serve, what we solve, how we talk, and how to route every prospect to the right brand. Built for everyone, written for sales.

VERSION

1.0 · 2026

OWNER

[Assign an owner]

REVIEW

Quarterly

STATUS

Internal use only

START HERE

How to use this playbook

Three tiers: the **Foundation** (read once), the **Message** (how we position and talk), and the **Sales Toolkit** (use it on every call). If you only have 30 seconds before a call, jump to the routing matrix and the cheat sheet.

ONE RULE ABOVE ALL

We are strategists and advisors, **not a college**. We do not grant degrees or award credit, our accredited partner universities do. Every rep must use the compliance line in How we talk and never promise a specific credit transfer, a guaranteed job, or a salary. When in doubt, under-promise.

01 · THE ECOSYSTEM

One mission, three front doors

Every brand exists to do the same thing: help a student earn a **real, accredited bachelor's degree** faster and for far less by strategizing the smartest path, then handing them a roadmap and support to the finish. We meet three different people at three different doors.

Smarter by 1 Degree

High school + bachelor's · the value path

For	Parents of homeschooled teens (13-18)
Gets	Diploma + accredited bachelor's, done together
Price	\$349 to start, then \$249 / class, pay-as-you-go
Vibe	Flexible, self-directed, budget-first

Compass Virtual Academy

Accredited online private high school · premium

For	Parents who want a structured private-school experience
Gets	WASC private-school diploma + accredited BBA, advisor-led
Price	\$7,000 / year (4 × \$1,750), all-inclusive
Vibe	White-glove, done-for-you, prestige

SB1D

Adults & Heroes · career advancement

For	Working adults & first responders / military
Gets	Accredited BBA in ~1 year
Price	\$7,995 flat + \$349 advising (waived for Heroes)
Vibe	Fast, benefits-funded, honor-forward

The routing matrix — which brand for whom

Compass and Smarter by 1 Degree serve the same teen outcome, so lead with **experience vs. price**, not "cheaper." Their yearly costs are similar; Compass earns its keep on structure and advising.

IF THE PROSPECT IS...	THEIR REAL GOAL	ROUTE TO	LEAD WITH	DON'T PITCH
Homeschool parent of a teen, budget-conscious, wants to drive it themselves & pay per class	Lowest all-in cost + flexibility	Smarter by 1 Degree	~80% savings, pay-as-you-go, no SAT/ACT, ESA-funded	Compass (too structured/priced)
Parent of a teen who wants a "real school" to run it, an advisor, and hand-holding	Structure, safety, done-for-you	Compass Virtual Academy	Private-school experience, Academic Advisor, all-inclusive, WASC	Price-shopping (sell the experience)
Working adult who needs a bachelor's to advance / was passed over	A degree, fast, around a job	SB1D (Adults)	~1 year, \$7,995 flat, pay-per-class, fits your schedule	The teen brands
Police / fire / EMS / military needing a degree for promotion	Promotion unlock, paid by benefits	SB1D (Heroes)	Academy/JST credit, \$0 out of pocket, fee waived	Full-price framing

THREE TELL-TALE QUESTIONS TO PLACE ANYONE FAST

1. **Is this for a teen or an adult?** Teen → a high-school brand. Adult → SB1D.
2. **(Teen) Do you want a school to run it for you, or drive it yourself and pay per class?** Run it for me → Compass. Drive it myself → Smarter by 1 Degree.
3. **(Adult) Are you a first responder or military?** Yes → SB1D Heroes track (credit for training, benefits, waived fee).

02 · FOUNDATION

Who we are

Mission

Every student deserves more than a diploma, they deserve **direction, purpose, and a future they're excited about**. We help students earn a real, accredited bachelor's degree faster, debt-free, and for a fraction of the cost by strategizing the smartest path, not taking shortcuts.

The story

Founder **Janine Deems** is an education strategist with 25 years of teaching experience. She homeschooled her own daughter to a **bachelor's degree by age 16**, then turned that playbook into a company. The ecosystem has since helped **10,000+ students**.

Positioning

For families and adults who refuse to overpay in money and years for a degree, **Smarter by 1 Degree** is the strategy-and-support partner that maps the fastest, cheapest, fully accredited path to a real bachelor's, **unlike** traditional college or DIY dual-enrollment, because we choose the university first and reverse-engineer every class so nothing is wasted.

Messaging pillars

- Learn once, earn twice
- Work smarter, not harder
- A real, accredited degree
- Debt-free 8 years ahead

How the credential actually works (know this cold)

PIECE	WHAT IT IS	WHO'S ACCOUNTABLE
Us	Strategy, degree planning, roadmap, advising, and affordable self-paced courses	Smarter by 1 Degree / Compass / SB1D
The credits	Course credits recommended for transfer by ACE, NCCRS, and DEAC's Approved Quality Curriculum	Third-party evaluators
The degree	The actual bachelor's diploma is granted by an accredited partner university	Partner universities (below)
HS accreditation	Compass is a WASC-accredited private high school	Compass Virtual Academy

Partner universities: Excelsior University (regionally accredited, Middle States) · Thomas Edison State University (regional) · Niagara University (Middle States) · Bellevue University (regional) · Crestpoint University (nationally accredited, DEAC / CHEA-recognized).

COMPLIANCE LINE — USE IT VERBATIM WHEN ASKED "ARE YOU THE SCHOOL?"

"[Brand] provides college advising and degree planning. It is not a college or university and does not confer degrees or award credit. Your degree is granted by an accredited partner university." Never say we grant degrees or guarantee a specific credit transfers, that depends on the chosen university's policy.

03 · HOW WE TALK

Voice & language

One voice across all three brands: **confident, warm, plain-spoken, and always forward**. We speak to teens like capable adults and to parents like partners. We sell momentum, not fear. (Full visual system: the [Momentum brand guide](#).)

DO SAY

- "There's a better way to do high school."
- "Learn once, earn twice." / "Work smarter, not harder."
- "A real, accredited degree, debt-free."
- "You're already moving, let's go further."
- Plain English, active voice, a warm teacher-friend tone.

DON'T SAY

- Fear bait: "Don't fall behind," "you'll regret it."
- Jargon: "synergistic," "revolutionary learning solution."
- Over-promises: "guaranteed job," "guaranteed salary," "your credits *will* transfer."
- "We're a college/university" or "we grant degrees."
- Talking down to a teenager.

Key phrases by brand

BRAND	SIGNATURE PHRASES TO REUSE
Smarter by 1 Degree	"Rethink high school." · "No fluff, no busywork." · "Learn to mastery." · "~80% savings." · "No ACTs or SATs." · "We do 95% for you."
Compass	"Learn ONCE, earn TWICE." · "Accredited online private school." · "Quality, not quantity." · "A competitive advantage that saves 4 years." · "Completely debt-free."
SB1D (Adults/Heroes)	"Same degree, less money." · "College on your terms." · "Fast, flexible, affordable." · "Honoring your service." · "Use your benefits, zero out of pocket."

Vocabulary & words to avoid

strategy / roadmap

accredited partner university

recommended for transfer

flex-paced / mastery

debt-free

Heroes

× "our accreditation"

× "we grant your degree"

× "guaranteed"

× "college" (for us)

× "cheap" (say "affordable")

Note on "degree": in our world "degree" means a **bachelor's / academic degree**, always. Say what you mean.

04 · THE BRANDS

A deep dive on each brand

Each brand below follows the same layout: positioning, the avatar, pains → solutions, what's unique, the offer, how they sign up, proof, elevator pitch, discovery questions, and objection cards.

Smarter by 1 Degree

A homeschool-native strategy service that helps a teen graduate high school holding both a diploma and an accredited bachelor's, debt-free, for ~80% less, pay-as-you-go.

THE AVATAR — THE HOMESCHOOL PARENT

WHO	A homeschool mom of a 13-18-year-old, often with several kids. Values-driven, faith-adjacent, already outside traditional school by choice.
JOB TO BE DONE	Give her teen a debt-free head start and a real credential without her having to build the whole plan herself.
WHAT SHE WEIGHS	Cost/value first, then legitimacy (accreditation), flexibility, and fit for how her teen learns.
TRIGGER	Teen entering high school + sticker-shock of \$100K college; discovering ESA/school-choice funds; meeting us at a homeschool convention.
HOPES	Debt-free launch, a bachelor's years early, time freed for sports/scouts/work/travel, "direction and purpose."
FEARS	Debt, wasted years, "is this legit?", managing it all alone, test anxiety for an ADHD/dyslexic teen.
INFLUENCERS	Other homeschool moms, convention speakers, her faith community.

PAIN → WHAT SOLVES IT

\$100K+ college cost / debt

Degree under \$10K, ~80% off, pay-per-class

4 wasted years after high school

"Learn once, earn twice" dual credit

Parent overwhelm (transcripts, planning)

"We do 95% for you" + roadmap

Test anxiety / learning differences

No SAT/ACT, self-paced, bite-sized lessons

WHAT'S UNIQUE

Diploma + bachelor's at once

University-first reverse planning

Pay-as-you-go, no lock-in

Built for homeschoolers

ESA / ClassWallet approved

THE OFFER & PRICING

Start Free consult → RoadMap; enroll = **\$349** (\$100 admin + first class)

Per class **\$249**, pay as you go (vs. \$975-\$3,700 elsewhere)

Full degree Typically **under \$10K** all-in (vs. up to \$141K at list)

Partner Excelsior University & others · **ESA/ClassWallet** accepted

HOW THEY SIGN UP

Homeschool convention booth / referral → free weekly **teen webinar** + sample class → free **1-on-1 Zoom consult** (builds the RoadMap, the real conversion moment) → enroll at \$349 → \$249/class to graduation.

PROOF TO DROP

10,000+ students · founder's daughter earned a degree at 16 · Excelsior lists us as a partner · ESA-approved in AZ, UT, AR, NH, FL, SC, TX + more · named teen graduates at 16-19.

30-SECOND ELEVATOR PITCH

"What if your teen could finish high school already holding an accredited bachelor's degree, debt-free, without a single SAT? We map every class so it counts twice, once for the diploma, once for the degree, and you pay as you go, about \$249 a class. Most families finish the whole degree for under ten thousand dollars. Want me to show you the roadmap for your student?"

Objections

"Is this even legit? Is it a real degree?"

MEANS Show me proof of accreditation.

REFRAME **Fair question, and the right one to ask.** The degree isn't from us, it's from an accredited partner university, the same degree a traditional student earns.

PROOF Excelsior (Middle States) lists us as a partner; credits are ACE/NCCRS/DEAC-recommended; 10,000+ students.

FOLLOW-UP "Would it help if I showed you exactly which university would grant your teen's degree?"

"How can it possibly be that cheap?"

MEANS What's the catch?

REFRAME It's **strategy, not a shortcut**. We use transfer-credit partnerships and pay-per-class instead of full university tuition, so you only pay for what you take.

PROOF \$249/class vs. \$975-\$3,700 elsewhere; under \$10K all-in.

FOLLOW-UP "Do you have ESA or school-choice funds? Many families cover it that way."

Compass Virtual Academy

An accredited online private high school where a teen graduates in four years with a diploma and an accredited BBA, advisor-led, all-inclusive, white-glove.

THE AVATAR — THE STRUCTURE-SEEKING PARENT

WHO	Intentional parent of a 9th–12th grader who wants a "real school," not a course library. Often ESA-funded in AZ/FL/UT/TX.
JOB TO BE DONE	Hand the whole thing to a trusted school, curriculum, plan, advisor, diploma, degree, so they don't assemble it.
WHAT THEY WEIGH	Experience, structure, safety, accreditation, and outcomes, over lowest price.
TRIGGER	Frustration with public school + desire for a premium alternative; ESA funds available.
HOPES	A structured, safe, prestigious path; a bachelor's by 18; a named school and advisor guiding it.
FEARS	Chaos / no support; "will colleges/employers respect it?"; their teen falling through the cracks.
INFLUENCERS	Spouse, ESA community, other private-school families.

PAIN → WHAT SOLVES IT

Public-school busywork & wasted time

Mastery-based, ~3 hrs/day, degree included

Homeschool "assemble-it-yourself" burden

All-in-one: advisor, curriculum, transcript, diploma

No structure / accountability

Named Head of School + 1-on-1 advisor plan

4 extra years + debt after HS

Graduates debt-free with a BBA in hand

WHAT'S UNIQUE (PREMIUM MARKERS)

- WASC-accredited private school
- Named Head of School
- 1-on-1 Academic Advisor
- All-inclusive, no upsells
- Structured 4-year plan

THE OFFER & PRICING

Tuition	\$7,000 / year, four quarterly payments of \$1,750
Included	HS diploma + accredited BBA + advising, no extra fees
Degree	Crestpoint University BBA (DEAC) · HS is WASC-accredited
Pay with	ESA: ClassWallet, EMA (FL), Odyssey + cards

HOW THEY SIGN UP / ADMISSIONS

Free 15-minute consult with an Academic Advisor (maps the 4-year plan) → "Reserve your spot" / Enroll Today. Open enrollment, start anytime; year runs Aug-May. **Note:** full-year commitment, no refunds, set the expectation kindly.

PROOF TO DROP

WASC accreditation · Crestpoint (DEAC/CHEA) · founder Janine Deems as Head of School · 2024 grad Ava H. earned diploma + bachelor's via AZ ESA.

30-SECOND ELEVATOR PITCH

"Compass is an accredited online private high school where your teen graduates in four years with a diploma *and* an accredited bachelor's degree, planned one-on-one with an academic advisor. It's about three hours a day, no busywork, no SATs, and it's all-inclusive, tuition covers the degree too. Many families fund it with ESA. Want to book a fifteen-minute call to map your teen's four years?"

Objections

"It's not really cheaper than Smarter by 1 Degree."

MEANS Justify the premium.

REFRAME **You're right, they're close on price, and that's the point.** Compass isn't the budget option; it's the **done-for-you private school**, a named school, an advisor mapping all four years, and structure so nothing falls on you.

PROOF WASC private-school accreditation, 1-on-1 advising, all-inclusive tuition.

FOLLOW-UP "Do you want to run the plan yourself, or have a school run it for you?" (self → route to Smarter by 1 Degree.)

"Will colleges and employers respect a degree from a national-accredited school?"

MEANS Reduce my risk / reputation worry.

REFRAME Great question. The bachelor's is granted by **Crestpoint University, a DEAC-accredited, CHEA-recognized university**. The high school is **WASC**-accredited.

PROOF Accreditor names; real 2024 graduate outcome.

FOLLOW-UP "Is there a specific next step, a job or grad program, you want it to support? Let's check the fit."

HONEST GAP FOR REPS TO COACH

Compass publishes little on **which colleges/employers accept the degree**, transfer of Crestpoint credits, or grad-school acceptance, and DEAC is **national**, not regional, accreditation. Be ready to explain the difference plainly and set realistic expectations rather than dodge it.

SB1D

A degree-completion advising service that gets working adults, veterans, and first responders an accredited bachelor's in about **one year** for a flat **\$7,995**, ~80% off.

AVATAR A — THE CAREER-ADVANCEMENT ADULT

WHO	28–50, employed full-time, some prior credit but never finished. Family + job responsibilities.
JOB TO BE DONE	Get the degree a promotion/role requires, without quitting, without debt.
TRIGGER	Passed over for a promotion that "requires a degree"; a role they can't reach; "it's finally time."
FEARS	"Too late" after years away; debt; not fitting school around work.

AVATAR B — THE HERO (FIRST RESPONDER / MILITARY)

WHO	Police, fire, EMS, active/veteran military. Shift workers with training credit sitting unused.
JOB TO BE DONE	Unlock a rank/promotion that requires a bachelor's, paid by benefits.
TRIGGER	Promotion gate; learning academy/JST training converts to credit; union endorsement.
FEARS	No time around shifts; paying out of pocket; training "won't count."

PAIN → WHAT SOLVES IT

"A degree I need is 4 years away"

Accredited BBA in ~1 year

Can't afford it / debt

\$7,995 flat vs ~\$39K; benefits = \$0 out of pocket

Shift work, no fixed schedule

Asynchronous, anytime, pay-per-class

"It's too late for me"

25 yrs out → graduated in 14 months

WHAT'S UNIQUE

~1-year degree

Flat \$7,995

"Not paid by the university"

Academy credit (39–40)

JST military credit

Union-endorsed

THE OFFER & PRICING

Degree	Accredited BBA (120 credits), ~1 year
Price	\$7,995 flat (vs ~\$39,195) + \$349 advising, waived for Heroes
Heroes credit	39–40 credits for academy training; JST for military
Fund it	Tuition assistance, reimbursement, FAFSA, military aid → \$0 out of pocket

HOW THEY SIGN UP

Free weekly **webinar** + **demo class** → free **consultation** (transcript/JST eval + custom Map) → advising fee (waived for Heroes) → enroll, pay-per-class to graduation. Dedicated union landing pages (e.g., PLEA).

PROOF TO DROP

Accredited partners (Excelsior, TESU, Bellevue, Niagara, Crestpoint) · 10,000+ students · "62% of employers require a degree" · union endorsements (NAPO, APA, PLEA, LVPPA) · Terri P.: 25 yrs out → BBA in 14 months.

30-SECOND ELEVATOR PITCH

"If a promotion is stuck behind a bachelor's degree, we get working adults and first responders an accredited degree in about a year, for a flat \$7,995, roughly 80% less than a university. If you're a first responder, your academy training likely counts for 39–40 credits, and benefits can cover it so you pay nothing out of pocket. Want me to evaluate your transcript on a free call and map your fastest path?"

Objections

"It's too late, I've been out of school for years."

MEANS	Reassure me I can actually do this.
REFRAME	That's exactly who this is built for. Classes are self-paced and built around a working life, and prior credit gets you started ahead.
PROOF	Terri P.: 25 years out, graduated in 14 months.
FOLLOW-UP	"Want me to pull your old transcript and show you how much you're already partway to?"

"I can't afford to pay out of pocket." (Heroes)

MEANS	Show me the funding path.
REFRAME	Most Heroes pay zero out of pocket , benefits, tuition assistance, or FAFSA cover it, and we waive the \$349 fee for first responders and military.
PROOF	Academy = 39-40 credits; JST evaluation; union endorsements.
FOLLOW-UP	"What benefits do you have available? Let's see what gets you to \$0."

05 · SALES TOOLKIT

The shared playbook

The buyer journey & your job at each step

STAGE	WHAT'S HAPPENING	YOUR JOB
1. Awareness	Convention booth, webinar, referral, ad	Earn the free consult. Lead with the outcome ("a degree by graduation / in a year"), not features.
2. Consultation	Free 1-on-1 Zoom, the conversion event	Discover (below), evaluate transcripts, and build the RoadMap . Make it real and specific to their student.
3. Enroll	\$349 / reserve spot / advising fee	Remove the money barrier (per-class, ESA, benefits). Confirm fit and next class.
4. Support	Courses + advising to graduation	Set expectations, hand off cleanly, and ask for the referral / review.

Discovery & qualifying questions (70% them talking)

Placement & goal

- "Is this for a teen or for you / an adult?" (routes the brand)
- "What are you hoping they'll be doing 1-2 years after they finish?"

Trigger & cost of inaction

- "What's making now the right time to look at this?"
- "If nothing changes over the next year, what happens?"

Fit & obstacles

- "How does your teen learn best?" / "What does your work schedule look like?"
- "What would need to be true for this to work with your budget and time?"

Money path

- "Do you have ESA / school-choice funds?" (teens) · "What education benefits do you have?" (Heroes)

Decision

- "Who else is part of this decision with you?" · "What does the right program have to include for you to say yes?"

Objection-handling framework

Every objection: **Acknowledge → Reframe → Proof → Follow-up question**. Validate the concern, flip it to the real need underneath, deliver one specific proof point, then ask a question that moves forward. The per-brand objection cards above are pre-filled examples. Common cross-brand ones:

OBJECTION	THE REAL NEED	LEAD PROOF
"Is it legit / accredited?"	Proof of legitimacy	Accredited partner university grants the degree; name it; 10,000+ students.
"How is it so cheap?"	Find the catch	Strategy + transfer credit + pay-per-class, not a shortcut.
"Are you the school?"	Understand the model	Compliance line: we advise; accredited partners grant the degree.
"I need to think / talk to my spouse."	Not enough certainty yet	Book the free consult / RoadMap so the decision is concrete, and invite the spouse.

Cross-sell & step-up paths

- **Compass** $\rightleftharpoons$ **Smarter by 1 Degree**: if a teen family loves the outcome but wants a lighter, pay-per-class approach, step them *down* to Smarter by 1 Degree; if they want more structure and hand-holding, step them *up* to Compass.
- **Parent** $\rightarrow$ **SB1D (Adults)**: a homeschool parent who mentions their own stalled degree is a warm SB1D lead. Ask.
- **Graduate** $\rightarrow$ **grad school**: Crestpoint grads have on-ramps (e.g., SNHU discount, UMGC), a natural next conversation.

06 • CHEAT SHEET

One glance before any call

Smarter by 1 Degree

\$349 start · **\$249/class**

Who: Homeschool parent of a teen, budget-first.

Win: Diploma + bachelor's, ~80% off, no SAT/ACT, ESA.

Top objection: "Is it legit?" $\rightarrow$ accredited partner grants the degree.

CTA: Free consult $\rightarrow$ RoadMap.

Compass Virtual Academy

\$7,000/yr (4 × \$1,750)

Who: Parent who wants a structured private school.

Win: WASC private school + BBA, advisor-led, all-inclusive.

Top objection: "Not cheaper" → sell the done-for-you experience.

CTA: Free 15-min advisor consult.

SB1D · Adults & Heroes

\$7,995 flat · ~1 year

Who: Working adult / first responder needing a degree.

Win: Fast, benefits-funded, academy/JST credit, \$0 out of pocket.

Top objection: "Too late" → 25 yrs out → 14 months.

CTA: Free consult + transcript eval.

DATA CAVEATS — KEEP US HONEST & COMPLIANT

Savings figures vary across our sites (70–80%). **Pick one number per asset**, default to ~80% with the "\$7,995 vs ~\$39K" and "under \$10K vs up to \$141K" anchors. Never promise a specific credit transfers, a job, or a salary. Always use the "not a college" compliance line. This playbook is **internal**; confirm any new stat before putting it in front of a prospect.

Smarter by 1 Degree Ecosystem — Team & Sales Playbook · Version 1.0 · Internal use only. · **Momentum brand guide** · **Brand hub** →

Owner: [assign] · Review quarterly · Built on research of smarterby1degree.com, sb1d.com, compassvirtualacademy.com. Verify pricing & accreditation details before external use.